

Targeting

This section is the campaign's roadmap for where to spend money and where not to. Every number in this section comes from the county-level data workbook (159 GA counties, May 2026 voter registration, six election cycles 2018 through 2024).¹ The workbook is the source of truth; this section translates the numbers into a plan.

Executive Summary

Three pieces of work define this campaign. Each one maps to a specific bucket of Georgia counties, a specific kind of voter, and a specific spend strategy.

MOBILIZE: turn out 602,753 reliable Republicans who skip midterms.

There are 56 counties classified Strong R with Low or Mid turnout.² They contain 1,319,295 active voters, of whom 602,753 are not projected to show up in 2026.³ These are people who already vote Republican when they vote. The campaign's only job is to get them to the polls. Every dollar spent on turnout here produces a near-guaranteed Collins vote.

PERSUADE: win back 356,606 Kemp-but-not-Walker voters in suburban Atlanta.

In 2022, 356,606 Georgians cast a Republican ballot for governor (Brian Kemp) but a non-Republican ballot for U.S. Senate (rejecting Herschel Walker).⁴ They are already Republican-leaning voters who drew a sharp line at Walker. They are concentrated in the educated suburban arc around Atlanta: Oconee, Forsyth, Cherokee, Hall, Fayette, and Cobb. These voters do not need to be converted from Democrat to Republican; they need to be re-unified with the Republican ticket. That is a meaningfully lower bar than persuasion from scratch.

DEFEND: stay out of Lean D and Strong D counties, except Cobb.

Georgia's Lean D and Strong D counties together hold 3,749,141 active voters, about 51% of the state. But because Republican vote share in those counties is low, they only produce a small fraction of Collins's projected total. Money spent on turnout in these counties activates Ossoff voters more than

1 GA County Master w_ Media Market workbook (v8), county_data_with_markets tab. 159 county rows.

2 Strong R counties at Low and Mid turnout tiers, filtered from county_data_with_markets cols BA (lean_bucket) and BB (turnout_tier).

3 Active voters: county_data_with_markets col X (active_voters_2026). Mobilization universe: col BC (mobilization_universe), summed across the 56 Strong R Mobilize counties.

4 GA County Master workbook, Summary tab cell B9. Calculated as the sum across all 159 counties of (active voters multiplied by Kemp-Walker gap in percentage points divided by 100). Per-county values stored in county_data_with_markets col BB (persuasion_universe), generated in georgia_targeting_ed.ipynb.

Collins voters. The one exception is Cobb County, which is technically Lean D but holds the single largest persuasion pool in the state (35,131 split-ticket voters).⁵ Cobb is the one place to fight on enemy ground.

The Path to Victory

Georgia uses a 50%+1 rule.⁶ If no candidate clears that threshold on November 3, the top two finishers go to a December 1 runoff. The campaign is targeting two numbers.

The first target is the floor: 2,069,625 votes.⁷ That is 50% + 1 of the 4,139,248 votes the model expects to be cast statewide. Hitting this number on November 3 means Collins wins outright and avoids a runoff. The runoff is historically bad for Republicans in Georgia: both U.S. Senate runoffs in the last five years went to Democrats.⁸ The floor is the real working goal.

The second target is the cushion: 2,152,409 votes, or 52% of expected turnout.⁹ This is what the campaign should plan for. It absorbs late polling shifts, a bad debate night, or an Ossoff late ad buy. Planning to win 50% + 1 leaves no margin; planning to 52% does.

Here is where Collins starts and how far he has to go:

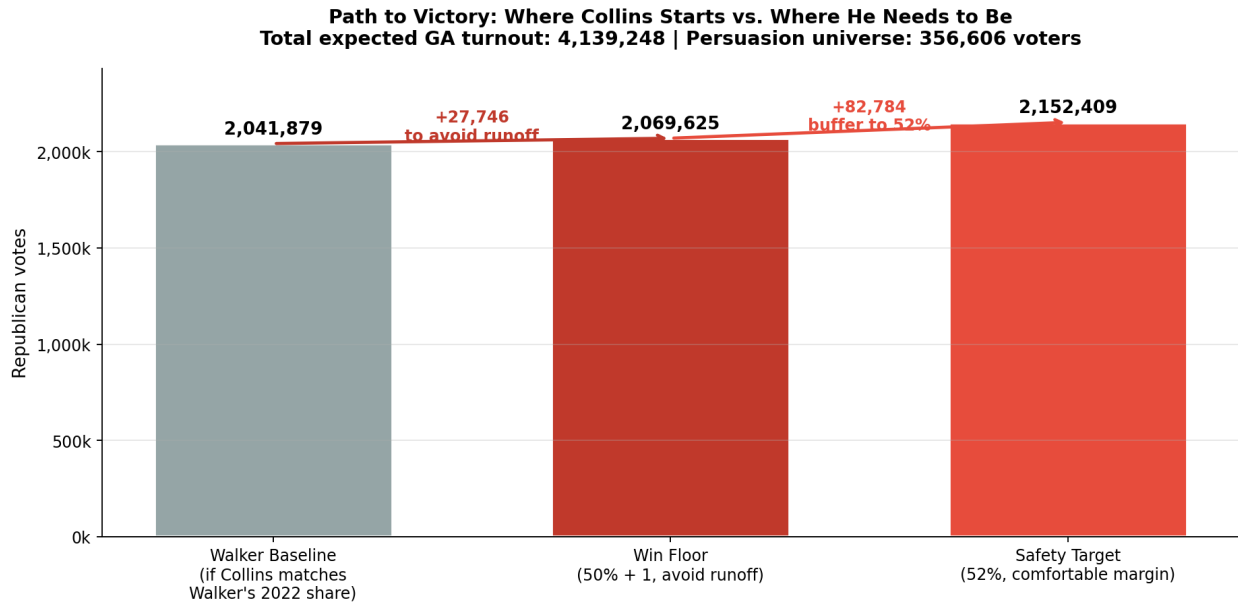
5 county_data_with_markets, Cobb County row, col BB (persuasion_universe).

6 Georgia 50%+1 rule: O.C.G.A. § 21-2-501. See <https://law.justia.com/codes/georgia/title-21/chapter-2/article-12/section-21-2-501/>

7 Summary tab cells B5 (win number 50%+1) and B4 (total expected voters).

8 Both recent Georgia U.S. Senate runoffs went to Democrats: Ossoff defeated Perdue (Jan 5, 2021) and Warnock defeated Walker (Dec 6, 2022). Georgia Secretary of State Election Results Archive. <https://sos.ga.gov/page/election-results>

9 Summary tab cell B6, formula =B4*0.52.



Walker baseline = sum across 159 counties of (county expected turnout x county Walker 2022 R%). Floor and Target = 50%+1 and 52% of 4,139,248 expected statewide turnout.

If Collins exactly matches Walker's 2022 county-by-county Republican share, the floor scenario, the model projects 2,041,879 Republican votes.¹⁰ That leaves a gap of 27,746 votes to clear the 50%+1 threshold and 110,530 votes to clear 52%. The campaign closes that gap through some combination of (1) mobilization in Strong R counties where Republican voters skipped 2022, and (2) persuasion in suburban Atlanta where Republican voters split their ticket. The math: if the campaign can convert 31% of the 356,606-voter persuasion universe, that alone covers the gap to 52%.¹¹

The Partisan Landscape: Red Counties, Purple Voters

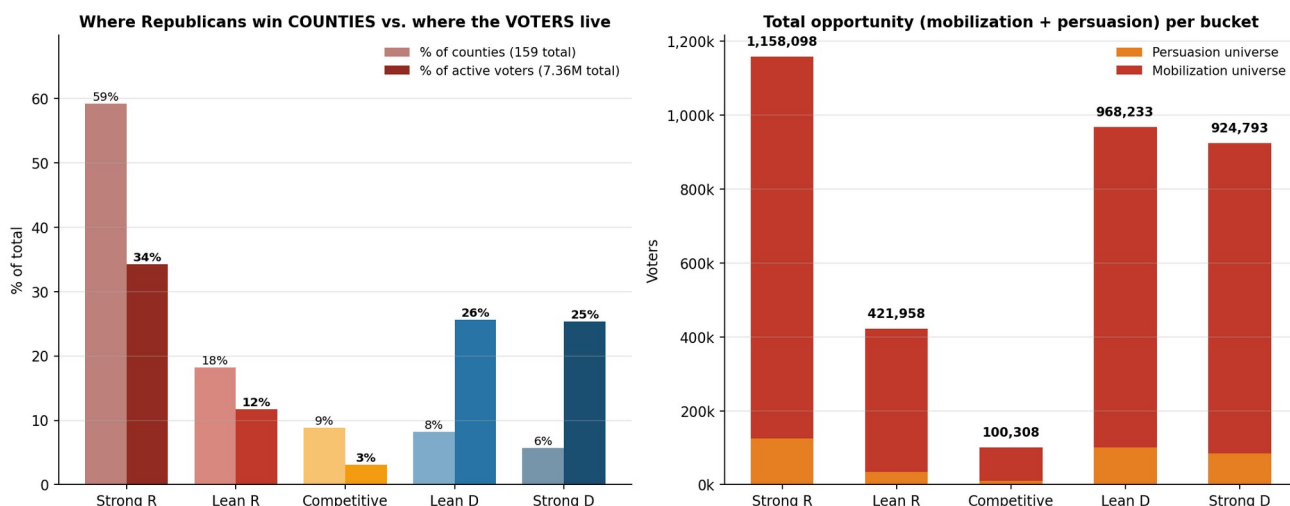
Georgia has 159 counties. Of those, 94 are Strong R, which is 59% of all counties, but only 34.2% of active voters (2,515,990).¹² At the other end, 22 counties are Lean D or Strong D (14% of counties), but they hold 51% of active voters (3,749,141).

¹⁰ Summary tab cell B7. Calculated as the sum across 159 counties of (expected turnout multiplied by Walker 2022 R%); per-county values in Summary tab col I.

¹¹ Summary tab cell B10, formula =B8/B9 (gap to 52% divided by total persuasion universe).

¹² Lean bucket counts: county_data_with_markets col BA (lean_bucket). Active voters by bucket: col X (active_voters_2026), summed.

Lean Bucket Overview: The Geography Problem and the Opportunity



Republicans win the most counties but Democrats hold the most voters. The persuasion plus mobilization opportunity is largest in Strong R, but Lean D matters because of sheer population size.

This is the geography problem at the center of every Georgia Republican Senate race. Walker carried more than 70% of counties in 2022 and still lost statewide by roughly 37,000 votes.¹³ Running up margins across rural Georgia is necessary but not sufficient. Collins also has to limit his losses in metro Atlanta. The targeting plan in this section is structured around both halves of that equation.

Lean Bucket	Counties	Active Voters	% of Active Voters
Strong R	94	2,515,990	34.2%
Lean R	29	862,633	11.7%
Competitive	14	228,268	3.1%
Lean D	13	1,884,016	25.6%
Strong D	9	1,865,125	25.4%

Turnout Projections: Growth and Decline

The model uses two turnout projections side by side. Method 1 (Conservative) assumes 2026 turnout in each county exactly repeats 2022 actuals, with a statewide total of 3,935,924.¹⁴ Method 2 (Expected) multiplies each county's 2022 total by its 2020-to-2024 presidential trend factor, capturing real growth or decline in voter engagement, with a statewide total of 4,139,248. Method 2 is the primary projection. The

¹³ Walker carried 117 of 159 counties in the November 2022 general election and lost the statewide vote to Warnock by 37,675 votes. Georgia Secretary of State, 2022 General Election Certified Results, U.S. Senate race. <https://sos.ga.gov/page/election-results-2022>

¹⁴ Method 1 and Method 2 statewide totals: sums of county_data_with_markets cols AQ (proj_2026_method1_votes) and AT (proj_2026_method2_votes).

places where the two methods diverge most are where the 2026 electorate is changing fastest, and where assumptions matter most.

Growing counties are the I-85 ex-urban Atlanta corridor.

Cherokee projects 14,475 more voters under Method 2 than Method 1.¹⁵ Fulton 9,200 more. Hall 9,199 more. Jackson 8,053 more. Paulding 7,672 more. These are the North Georgia and I-85 corridor counties absorbing new residents faster than anywhere else in the state. Jackson County alone grew 5.8% from July 2023 to July 2024, making it one of the top four fastest-growing counties in the country for that period.¹⁶ These are not just more people, they are more engaged voters. For the campaign, that means infrastructure investments in Cherokee, Hall, Jackson, and Paulding pay off bigger than a flat baseline would suggest.

Shrinking counties are urban, not rural.

DeKalb projects 3,868 fewer votes under Method 2 than Method 1. Richmond (Augusta) 2,494 fewer. Bibb (Macon) 1,188 fewer. Dougherty (Albany) 1,091 fewer. Clayton 420 fewer. Every one of these is a majority-urban county and a Democratic base county. At the same time, the Republican share in these places is creeping up: DeKalb went from 15.75% R in 2020 to 17.11% in 2024; Clayton from 14.08% to 15.11%.¹⁷ So Democratic base counties are producing fewer voters AND giving Republicans a slightly larger slice of the ones who do show up. Both trends move in Collins's favor: the Democratic wall is a little shorter than it used to be.

The Kemp-Walker Gap: The Persuasion Universe

The single most important metric in this analysis is the Kemp-Walker gap. In 2022, Georgians voted for governor and U.S. senator on the same day, on the same ballot. Kemp won the governor's race with 53.4% of the vote. Walker lost the Senate race with 48.5%.¹⁸ That is a 4.9-point statewide gap between two Republicans on the same ballot, and at the county level the gap is much wider in some places than others.

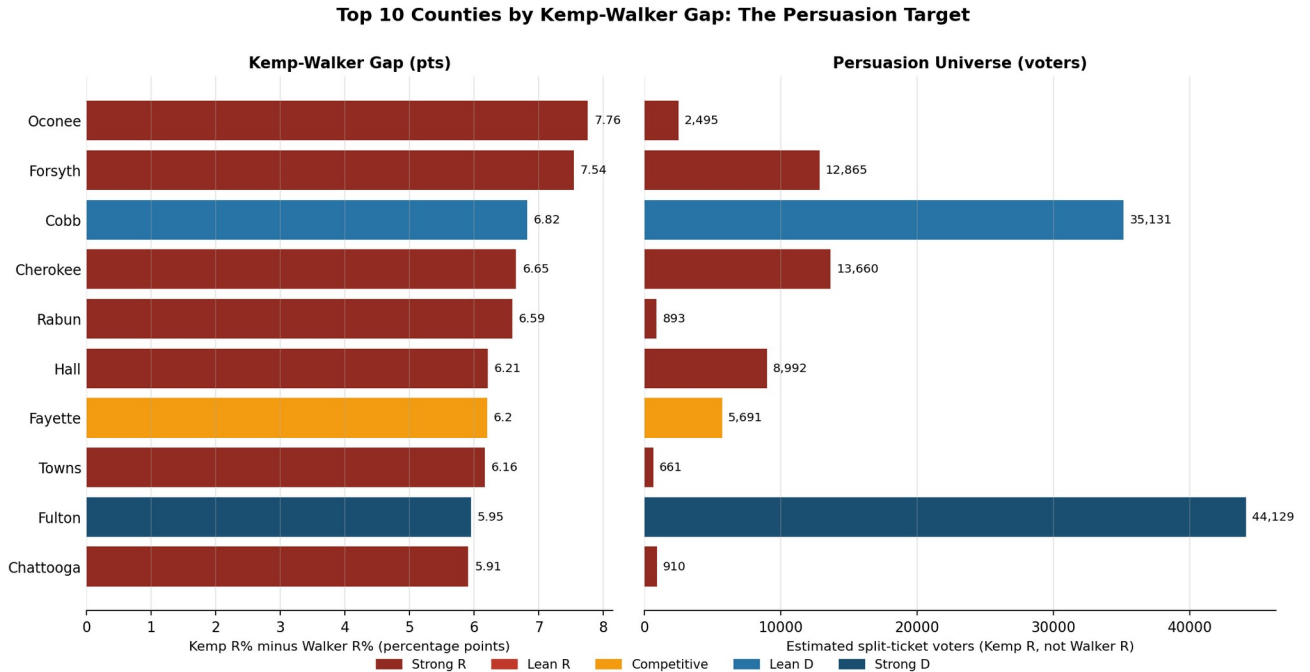
Those split-ticket voters, people who chose the Republican for governor but not for Senate, are the persuasion universe. Statewide, the pool is roughly 356,606 voters. They are not Democrats. They are not independents who need to be converted. They are Republican-leaning voters who voted Republican for one office on one day and refused to vote Republican for another office on the same day. The task is to reunify a ticket that split, not to flip voters across party lines. That is a meaningfully easier persuasion job.

15 Per-county turnout divergence: county_data_with_markets, col AT minus col AQ for each county.

16 U.S. Census Bureau, Vintage 2024 County Population Estimates, July 2023 to July 2024. <https://www.census.gov/data/tables/time-series/demo/popest/2020s-counties-total.html>

17 Republican vote share: county_data_with_markets col E (pres20_pct_r) and col V (pres24_pct_r) for DeKalb and Clayton rows.

18 Kemp 2022 (53.4%) and Walker 2022 (48.5%) statewide vote shares: Georgia Secretary of State, 2022 General Election Certified Results. <https://sos.ga.gov/page/election-results-2022>



Top 10 counties by Kemp-Walker gap. The persuasion target is concentrated in suburban and ex-urban Atlanta: educated, higher-income voters who voted Kemp but skipped Walker.

The counties with the biggest gaps cluster in the wealthy, educated suburban ring around Atlanta. This is not speculation; it matches every external account of the 2022 race. CNN's pre-election coverage described "white suburban Republican leaners for whom voting for Walker is a bridge too far" as the defining 2022 demographic.¹⁹ The New York Times found Kemp ran 20 points ahead of Walker in the wealthy northern Atlanta suburbs.²⁰ The persuasion playbook is to give those voters a Republican Senate candidate they can vote for in good conscience, which means the campaign messaging has to draw a sharp distinction between Collins and Walker, not lean into shared brand.

Cobb County is the single biggest persuasion target in Georgia.

Cobb is technically classified Lean D (partisan blend 41.38%), but its 6.82-point Kemp-Walker gap across 515,118 active voters produces a persuasion universe of 35,131 voters.²¹ That single county is bigger than the active voter population of most Georgia counties combined and is almost as large as Walker's entire 2022 statewide loss margin. Cobb is the one place in the Lean D bucket where the campaign should spend persuasion dollars.

¹⁹ Brownstein, Ron. "How Black voters and Brian Kemp could decide the Georgia Senate race." CNN, October 25, 2022. <https://www.cnn.com/2022/10/25/politics/georgia-senate-warnock-walker-kemp/index.html>

²⁰ Cohn, Nate. "Why Brian Kemp Will Run Far Ahead of Herschel Walker." The New York Times, November 4, 2022. <https://www.nytimes.com/2022/11/04/upshot/georgia-senate-kemp-walker.html>

²¹ Cobb County row in county_data_with_markets: col AX (partisan_blend_r), col AW (kemp_walker_gap_pts), col X (active_voters_2026), col BB (persuasion_universe).

County	K-W Gap (pts)	Lean Bucket	Active Voters	Persuasion Universe
Oconee	7.76	Strong R	32,157	2,495
Forsyth	7.54	Strong R	170,617	12,865
Cobb	6.82	Lean D	515,118	35,131
Cherokee	6.65	Strong R	205,421	13,660
Rabun	6.59	Strong R	13,553	893
Hall	6.21	Strong R	144,801	8,992
Fayette	6.2	Competitive	91,783	5,691
Towns	6.16	Strong R	10,737	661
Fulton	5.95	Strong D	741,659	44,129
Chattooga	5.91	Strong R	15,399	910

Per-county persuasion targets (Summary tab column J).

The targeting workbook turns the statewide persuasion universe into a per-county operational number. Column J in the Summary tab calculates, for each of the 159 counties, the specific number of Kemp-but-not-Walker voters the campaign must convert to close the gap to 52%. The formula is straightforward: each county's persuasion universe (column G) multiplied by 31% (the share of the statewide pool Collins needs to convert, from cell B10). Add column J to the Walker baseline in column I and you get column K, the total Republican vote target for that county. Sum column J across all 159 counties and the total equals B8, the gap to 52%. Sum column K and it equals B6, the 52% target.²²

What this means in practice: the top three counties by persuasion universe carry roughly a third of the total persuasion lift Collins needs. Fulton's persuasion pool is 44,129, with a target of 13,680 voters to convert (column J). Cobb's pool is 35,131, target 10,891. Gwinnett's pool is 35,034, target 10,861. The persuasion campaign cannot avoid these three counties, even though two of them (Fulton, Gwinnett) are Strong D / Lean D territory. The persuasion universe is concentrated where the population is, not where the partisan lean is. That is a different conclusion than what the lean-bucket analysis alone would suggest, and it is why the campaign needs both views side by side.

Rank	County	Market	Persuasion Universe (col G)	Target to Convert (col J)	Total County Target (col K)
1	Fulton	Atlanta	44,129	13,680	118,685

²² Summary tab column J: formula =G(persuasion universe per county) multiplied by Summary!B10 (the 31% conversion rate needed). Sum of col J across all 159 counties equals Summary!B8, the total gap to 52%.

2	Cobb	Atlanta	35,131	10,891	139,063
3	Gwinnett	Atlanta	35,034	10,861	127,713
4	DeKalb	Atlanta	20,691	6,414	47,826
5	Cherokee	Atlanta	13,660	4,235	94,823
6	Forsyth	Atlanta	12,865	3,988	74,554
7	Chatham	Savannah	10,369	3,214	46,795
8	Hall	Atlanta	8,992	2,788	60,939
9	Henry	Atlanta	6,641	2,059	36,483
10	Coweta	Atlanta	6,411	1,987	48,437

Operationally, this column is what the campaign hands to the field director, mail vendor, and digital team. For each county, it is the number to beat. If the campaign's tracking poll in October shows the campaign on pace to hit these per-county persuasion targets, the path to 52% is intact. If it falls short in Fulton, Cobb, or Gwinnett, those three counties alone account for enough of the gap that the floor is at risk.

Demographic Targets

The campaign's overall electorate is about 53.6% white, 29.1% Black, and 6.1% Hispanic plus Asian.²³ But those shares change sharply by lean bucket and turnout tier. The demographic composition of the actual target universe, the voters Collins needs to mobilize or persuade, looks meaningfully different from the statewide average.²⁴

Mobilize counties: target white men.

The 56 Strong R Mobilize counties are 73.4% white by active voter registration. In 2020, white women in those counties turned out at 38.7%; white men turned out at 34.1%, a 4.6-point gap.²⁵ White men are the highest-volume under-mobilized group in the Republican base. Field, mail, and radio in these counties should be designed around getting them to the polls. A secondary target exists in Hall, Whitfield, and Barrow, where roughly 29,582 Hispanic voters are registered in reliably Republican counties but turned out at just 7 to 13% in 2020.²⁶

23 Demographic registration shares from 2020 election baseline (georgiadata.org), applied to May 2026 active voter totals from county_data_with_markets col X. <https://www.georgiadata.org/>

24 Statewide demographic shares calculated from county_data_with_markets cols AG-AM (reg_2020_*) summed and divided by total active voters.

25 White women and white men turnout in the 56 Strong R Mobilize counties: county_data_with_markets cols AB (turnout_2020_white_female) and AC (turnout_2020_white_male), weighted by active voters.

26 Hispanic voter registration and turnout: county_data_with_markets cols AL (reg_2020_hispanic) and AE (turnout_2020_hispanic) for Hall, Whitfield, and Barrow rows.

Persuade counties: target white women.

The Kemp-Walker gap counties are 40 to 47% white women by registration, already high-propensity voters. The gap there is not turnout, it is candidate preference. The persuasion target is specifically the white, suburban, high-propensity Republican woman who voted Kemp and either skipped or crossed over on the Senate line in 2022. Messaging has to be about Collins as a credible, competent Republican who is not Walker.

Defensive counties: watch Black and Hispanic mobilization on the other side.

The 7 Lean D + Low Turnout counties hold a mobilization universe of 578,276 voters, approximately 35% Black, 12% Hispanic, and 41% white by registration. Black women in Georgia outperformed Black men by 6.06 points in 2020 turnout, meaning Black men and Hispanic voters are the most under-mobilized segments of the Democratic base.²⁷ They are also the most likely focus of Ossoff's ground game. The campaign should not invest in turnout here, but early-vote return rates among these groups are the leading indicator to watch for Ossoff's GOTV traction.

The Targeting Matrix

Every county in Georgia is classified by partisan lean (Strong R through Strong D) and projected turnout tier (Low / Mid / High). Each combination produces a recommended action. This is the single most useful tool in the targeting workbook: given a county, the cell tells the campaign exactly what to do with its budget there.

²⁷ Black women and Black men turnout (statewide weighted): county_data_with_markets cols Z (turnout_2020_black_female) and AA (turnout_2020_black_male).

Targeting Matrix: Lean Bucket × Turnout Tier 159 GA counties, color-coded by recommended action

	LOW turnout	MID turnout	HIGH turnout
Strong R	MOBILIZE 26 counties 597,116 active 286,357 mob.	MOBILIZE 30 counties 722,179 active 316,396 mob.	MAINTAIN 38 counties 1,196,695 active 429,515 mob.
Lean R	MOBILIZE + LIGHT PERSUADE 12 counties 271,767 active 135,880 mob.	MOBILIZE + LIGHT PERSUADE 9 counties 429,048 active 189,856 mob.	MOBILIZE + LIGHT PERSUADE 8 counties 161,818 active 61,582 mob.
Competitive	PERSUADE 4 counties 43,753 active 21,074 mob.	PERSUADE 7 counties 73,382 active 31,883 mob.	PERSUADE 3 counties 111,133 active 37,602 mob.
Lean D	DEFENSE / MIN INVEST 7 counties 1,169,927 active 578,276 mob.	DEFENSE 3 counties 193,165 active 87,893 mob.	DEFENSE 3 counties 520,924 active 200,878 mob.
Strong D	SKIP 4 counties 485,477 active 261,019 mob.	SKIP 4 counties 884,651 active 377,278 mob.	SKIP 1 counties 494,997 active 201,295 mob.

Recommended Action

- MAINTAIN
- MOBILIZE
- MOBILIZE + LIGHT PERSUADE
- PERSUADE
- DEFENSE
- DEFENSE / MIN INVEST
- SKIP

The targeting matrix. 159 counties, 5 lean buckets, 3 turnout tiers. Color = action; numbers in each cell = counties / active voters / mobilization universe.

The 56 Strong R + Mobilize cells (Low and Mid turnout combined) hold 1,319,295 active voters with a combined mobilization universe of 602,753. These voters do not need persuasion. They are reliable Republicans who skip midterms. Mobilization spending here produces near-guaranteed Republican votes with no persuasion risk.

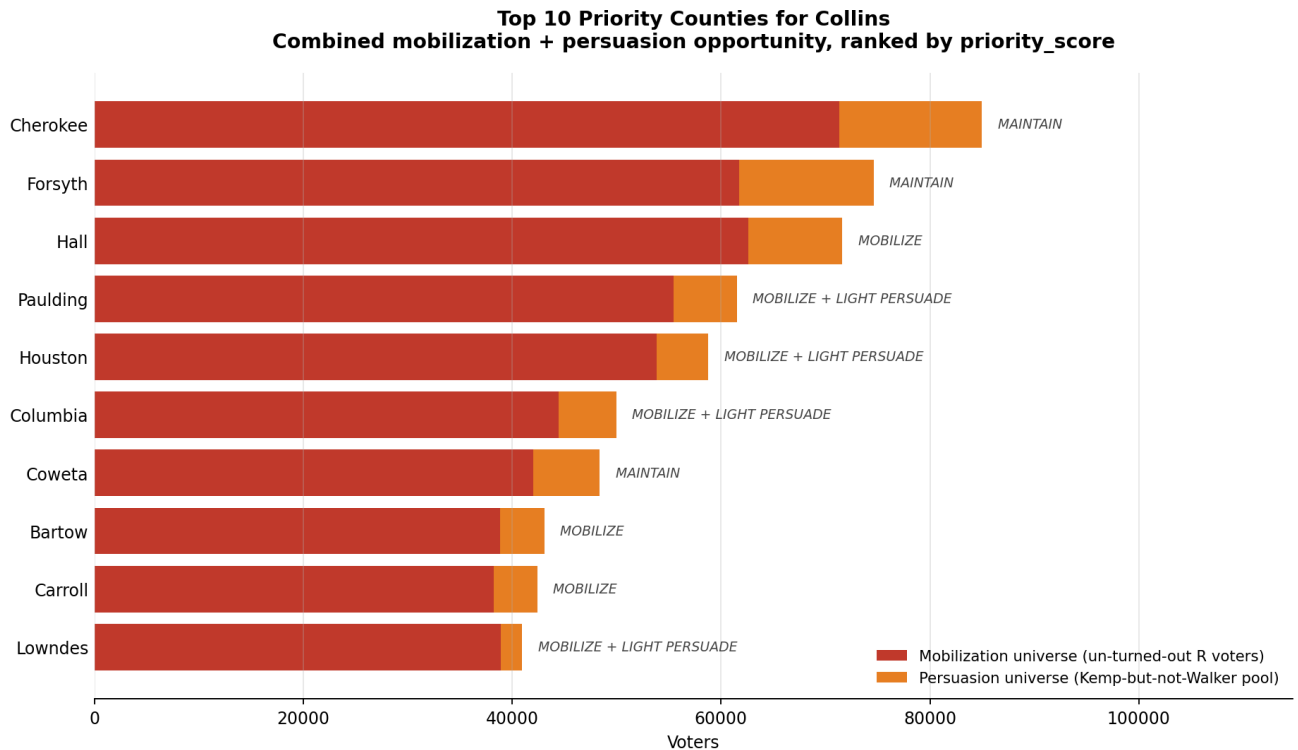
The 7 Competitive + Mid Turnout counties are the persuasion sweet spot. Close enough that messaging moves the margin, engaged enough that voters are reachable, but not so saturated that they are already locked in.

A counterintuitive finding: the largest absolute pools of persuadable voters are inside Strong R and Lean D counties, not Competitive ones. Strong R counties hold 125,830 of the 356,606 statewide persuasion universe (35%); Lean D holds 101,186 (28%); Strong D 85,201 (24%); Lean R 34,640 (10%); and Competitive only 9,749 (3%). The Competitive bucket has the smallest pool because it has the fewest total voters. Collins should focus persuasion inside the Strong R ex-urban Atlanta counties with large Kemp-Walker gaps, not just the narrow 14-county Competitive tier.

The 7 Lean D + Low Turnout counties are the most defensive cell of the matrix. They contain 1,169,927 active voters with a mobilization universe of 578,276 people not currently projected to vote. That is a sleeping giant for Ossoff. The campaign should not spend on turnout here. The play is to monitor the Ossoff ground game and adjust if the sleeping giant starts waking up.

Top Priority Counties

The full priority ranking is in the data workbook.²⁸ The top 10 counties by composite priority score are below. Priority score weights mobilization universe and persuasion universe together, weighted by each county's strategic value: Strong R counties weight mobilization heaviest, Competitive counties weight persuasion heaviest.



Top 10 priority counties for Collins. Combined mobilization plus persuasion opportunity.

Rank	County	Lean	Turnout	Action	Active	Persuasion	Mobilizati
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²⁸ Priority ranking: county_data_with_markets col BE (priority_rank), composite score generated in georgia_targeting_eda.ipynb.

					Voters		on
1	Cherokee	Strong R	High	MAINTAIN	205,421	13,660	71,315
2	Forsyth	Strong R	High	MAINTAIN	170,617	12,865	61,736
3	Hall	Strong R	Mid	MOBILIZE	144,801	8,992	62,597
4	Paulding	Lean R	Mid	MOBILIZE + LIGHT PERSUADE	129,833	6,063	55,448
5	Houston	Lean R	Mid	MOBILIZE + LIGHT PERSUADE	118,063	4,947	53,822
6	Columbia	Lean R	High	MOBILIZE + LIGHT PERSUADE	113,081	5,530	44,437
7	Coweta	Strong R	High	MAINTAIN	112,876	6,411	41,982
8	Bartow	Strong R	Low	MOBILIZE	84,194	4,201	38,864
9	Carroll	Strong R	Mid	MOBILIZE	86,559	4,172	38,223
10	Lowndes	Lean R	Low	MOBILIZE + LIGHT PERSUADE	74,568	2,051	38,883

Targeting Summary

The Collins campaign runs as the de facto Republican nominee from January 1, 2026 through November 3, 2026: ten months of general election against incumbent Jon Ossoff with no primary to fight. The targeting plan above structures that ten months around three concurrent workstreams.

Mobilization is the dominant spend in the Strong R + Mobilize cells, 56 rural and small-metro counties where 602,753 reliable Republicans need a reason to show up. Persuasion concentrates on the suburban Atlanta arc (Oconee, Forsyth, Cherokee, Hall, Cobb, Fayette), where 356,606 Kemp-but-not-Walker voters are the swing pool, with per-county conversion targets specified in column J of the Summary tab.

Defense means staying out of Lean D and Strong D counties (Cobb excepted), and monitoring early-vote return rates among Black men and Hispanic voters as the leading indicator for Ossoff's GOTV operation.

If Collins exactly matches Walker's 2022 county-by-county Republican share, he ends up at 2,041,879 votes. That is short of the 2,069,625 needed to clear 50% + 1 and avoid a runoff, and well short of the 2,152,409 target. The campaign closes that gap by outperforming Walker, through persuasion in suburban Atlanta, mobilization in rural Georgia, or both. The targeting framework in this section is the operational plan for outperforming the floor.²⁹

²⁹ Visualizations regenerated by targeting_visuals.py (CMI Campaign Plan folder), which reads directly from GA County Master w_ Media Market (8).xlsx and outputs the 5 PNGs embedded above.